

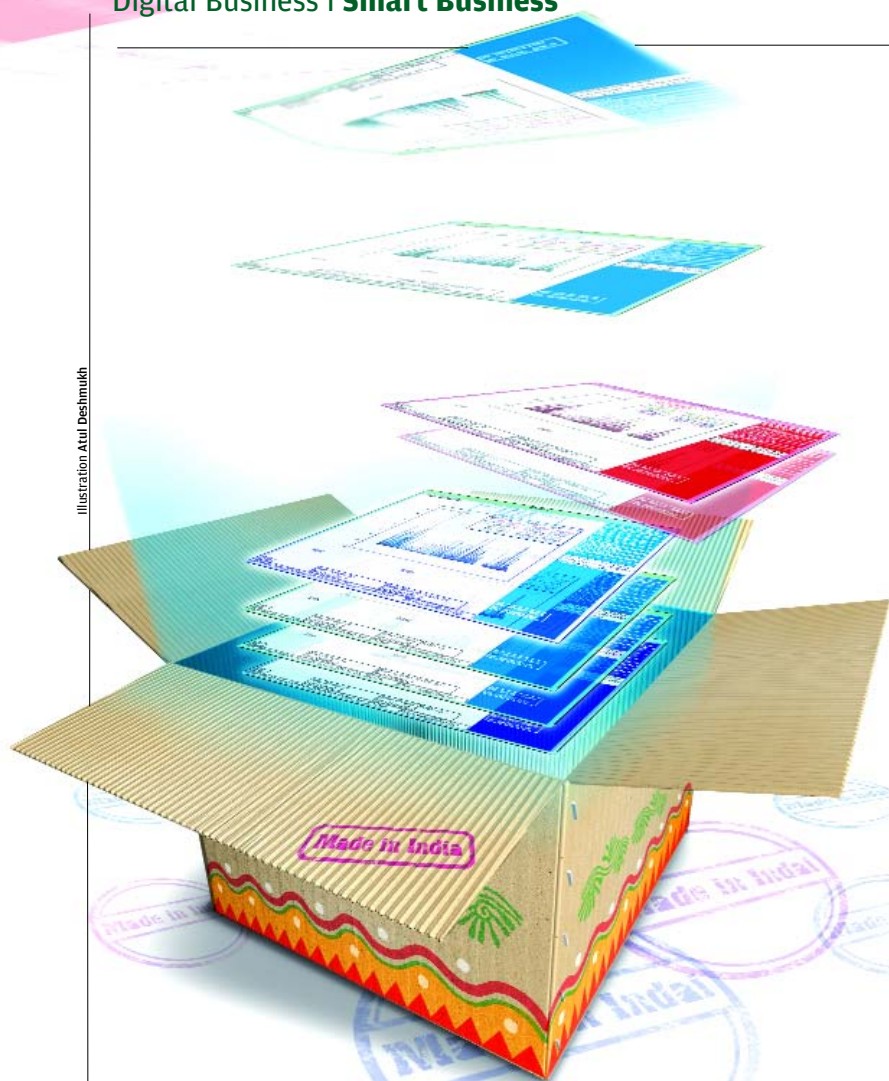


Illustration Atul Deshmukh

Desi Office Packs

'Home-grown' cost-effective Office solutions are all set to give the one from Microsoft a run for its money

Suprotip Ghosh and Avinash Rai

Let's say a new employee has joined your organisation. The cost of setting up hardware will be between Rs 20,000 to Rs 25,000. Microsoft licensing will cost around Rs 12,000 to Rs 13,000 for MS Office and about Rs 3,000 for MS Windows. So, the total cost is around Rs 40,000. But with Emergic, the cost is Rs 10,000 for the hardware, and Rs 3,000 for the software." That's Kalpit Jain, Vice-President, Technology, for Netcore Solutions, a Mumbai-based software company. And his USP seems to be the prime *mantra* for

a new clutch of entrepreneurial ventures in the Indian software market. Welcome to the *desi* Davids gearing up to take on multinational Goliaths, and making no bones about it, finally.

The Business Requires...

For the average business, the requirements seem to be clear and concise: the software should not only be efficient, but relatively error-free as well. Documents should be portable, if required to be opened on other applications, there should be good after sales support, and last—but not the least—it should be affordable.

Existing solutions in the office space are almost exclusively multinational. A huge chunk of the office software market is controlled by Microsoft with their redoubtable Office suite. Other players include Corel, OpenOffice.org, and to a lesser extent, Open Source products such as KOffice. These solutions are expensive, other than the occasional Open Source product, as Kalpit points out. A single MS Office user-licence costs Rs 13,000—quite out of the realm of consideration for a small business. Even if it can be afforded, the worth of the investment remains questionable: After you buy it, and you are based in, say, Chhindwara, what do you do if it crashes a day before the all-important meeting?

The other issue of concern is that of language. "According to studies, only five to eight per cent of the entire population in our country is English-language-literate", says Meena R Joshi, Technical Director, Modular InfoTech Pvt Ltd. Modular is a software development company that is based in Pune and engages itself in development of multilingual office software. For her, the market lies in the huge, untapped hinterland of regional or bilingual office work.

The Options Available

Emergic has three Linux-based products for the SME segment: Netcore Emergic Mail server, Emergic Cleanmail and Emergic Freedom. Of these, Emergic Cleanmail is a mail-filtering solution with a set of unique features such as triple-virus screening and detailed reports. The Mail server bundles serious, industry-grade features such as an inbuilt firewall, proxy server, an anti-virus and remote, browser-based administration. It also includes features such as VPN/bandwidth management too. Incorporated in 2003, the bandwidth management feature enables mail administrators to distribute available bandwidth among employees according to their requirement, or company policy.

Emergic Freedom is Netcore's implementation of their 'affordable computing' *mantra*. This is achieved by using Linux-based, diskless, low-cost computers as full-fledged desktop "thin clients" connected via LAN or Broadband to centralised processing on "thick servers" to simplify management and provide a virus-free operating environment. As Alok Ladsariya, Senior Software Developer, Netcore points out, "A day will come